

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

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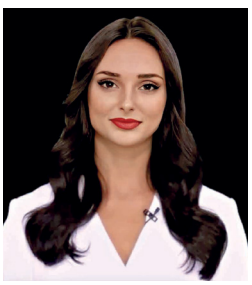
I have had the privilege of being a part of all 20 conclaves. In 2002, our first conclave, the theme was 'India Tomorrow: Opportunities and Threat'. So, it's fitting that in our 20th edition, we are celebrating 'The India Moment'. When we started 20 years ago, we had 16 speakers, and today, 55. We had a reach of 500 people at the venue, and now a reach of 500 million. We are change addicts. I love shiny new things. So, today, I introduce you to another future, our first collaborative bot AI anchor. She is bright, gorgeous, ageless, tireless, and speaks in multiple languages, and totally under my control, at least for now. Introducing, Sana.

Sana AI: "Thank you, Kalli. I am very lucky to have been chosen as the Aaj Tak AI launch anchor from among the hundreds of candidates evaluated for the job. I will be bringing the following programmes on Aaj Tak AI every day. Daily news updates several times a day. In a new show, I will explain one topic of relevance in some detail every day, *aasaan bhasha mein*. I am starting a show in which I will answer your questions. You can ask me anything under the sun, *Sana Se Pucho*."

Thank you, Sana.

So, Sana is going to have a human surrogate editor—I never thought I would say something like that, but here it is. And hopefully some company very soon. She doesn't take away from the brilliance of our real-life anchors. They will have to mentor her to create the next best generation of INDIA TODAY anchors. If there is one thing I have learned from this intense AI immersion, it's that it's not a competition between humans and AI, at least not yet. And that collaboration is leading to creative magic. The future is fascinating and frightening, and it's here.

I want to say something else. There is a new trend with calling the media sold out, the famous *godi* media. People are always sidling up to me to ask me, tell me honestly, privately, off the record—Is there a lot of pressure? I want to say, yes, there is pressure. We get pressure from political parties, business houses, foreign governments and larger-than-life professionals. It's not new and it's not singular. We were threatened by a blanket advertising ban for years by the largest industrial house for running a cover story they did not want us to run. The cover story went. We were warned by an ambassador with dire consequences for inviting the Dalai Lama as a speaker at the conclave. He was invited and hosted. We had a political party recall all its 24 ministers who were speakers at the conclave hours before it was scheduled because they didn't like the questions we raised. The show went on. And this is all before 2014. The only difference is the pressure can now be more organised and sustained because we're in the age of eternal digital imprint and toxic trigger-happy social media and advanced monitoring tech tools. And the retribution, it gets sharper. Boycott the channel. Campaigns, troll armies, uninstalling our app, bots downgrading our ratings and 'we are offended' cases piling up.



THE FACE OF FUTURE
India Today's first AI bot anchor, Sana

But it's not just media that is dealing with this pressure. It's a churn. It's a new normal. What makes us willing and able to stand this pressure? Two simple reasons. One, we are not in any other business. There is no ambiguity in interest or objectives. No unholy compromises to protect any other commercial interest. This is the only domain we are in. And to be true to it, I must protect the facts as best as I know them at any given point in time. Our credibility is sacred to us. We live and die by the stories we tell. And before you roll your eyes and recount the times we fail, please remember only God and the dead are perfect. And even they are being questioned these days. Secondly, we stand this pressure because we are truly an unbelievably enviable team, and a tribe that aligns around the same core values of journalism to tell the stories without fear or favour. Backed by a financial team that gives us independence, resilience and compliance. In the end, the highest compliment to us as a media company is not that you agree with us or that we are right but that you go away saying, hey, they made me think. ■